ROLL OF DISHONOUR

More than 30 legislators have been disqualified after being convicted in a criminal case. Here are some of the prominent names



INDIRA GANDHI

Year: June 1975; **Party:** Congress
Constituency: Lok Sabha MP from Rae Bareli, UP
Reason: The Allahabad HC convicted the then PM of electoral malpractices and debarred her from holding any elected post for six years. The SC overturned her conviction on Nov. 7, 1975



LALU PRASAD

Year: Sept. 2013
Party: RJD
Constituency: Lok Sabha MP from Saran, Bihar
Reason: Convicted in the fodder scam case, gets five-year jail term



RASHEED MASOOD

Year: Sept. 2013
Party: Congress
Constituency: RS MP from Saharanpur, UP
Reason: Convicted in the MBBS seats scam, gets four-year jail term



J. JAYALALITHAA

Year: Sept. 2014
Party: AIADMK
Constituency: MLA from R.K. Nagar, Tamil Nadu
Reason: Gets four years in jail in a disproportionate assets case. Loses CM chair



KULDEEP SINGH SENGAR

Year: Mar. 2020
Party: BJP
Constituency: MLA from Bangarmau, UP
Reason: Convicted in a rape case, sentenced to 10 years in jail



AZAM KHAN

Year: Oct. 2022
Party: SP
Constituency: MLA from Rampur Sadar, UP
Reason: Sentenced to three years in jail in a 2019 hate speech case



RAHUL GANDHI

Year: Mar. 2023
Party: Congress
Constituency: Lok Sabha MP from Wayanad, Kerala
Reason: Sentenced to two years in jail in a criminal defamation case

to gain political mileage in the Karnataka election as "the Congress didn't show any urgency to get a stay on his conviction to avoid disqualification". Indeed, in almost a week, the Congress has not approached any higher court seeking relief from the conviction and punishment.

The official line is that the legal team is taking time to translate the court order from Gujarati to English, but several Congress leaders admit in private that they want to prolong the issue to capitalise on public sympathy and turn it into political gain. A legal associate working for social worker Aabha Muralidharan, who has filed a plea in the Supreme Court challenging the immediate disqualification of legislators after conviction in a criminal case, told INDIA TODAY that the Congress legal team has asked them to go slow in the case.

"As the case itself is very weak, there is every possibility that we will get a stay and Rahul's conviction is nullified. In that case, the narrative of BJP hounding Rahul will fizzle out. So, we are taking our own sweet time," says a senior Congress leader. However, asked why his lawyers could not prevent the conviction in the first place if the case was weak, the blame is laid on Rahul's close associate Kanishka Singh. "He was monitoring the case and did not share details. The day Rahul went for the final verdict in the defamation case, even the Gujarat Congress Committee had no clue," says a Congress leader.

Rahul's aides claim that the disqualification will have little impact on the Congress leader's future as his primary objective is not to "become an MP or prime minister". They believe the "turnaround in Rahul's public image from Pappu to a serious and committed politician" on account of BJY has scared the BJP, hence Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union home minister Amit Shah's attempt to corner him thus. "When they came to know that he is not a Pappu and lakhs of people are walking with him, they got disturbed over the questions he raised in Parliament for which they don't have answers," Priyanka said in the meeting to protest Rahul's disqualification.

Several other Congress leaders also believe that more than BJY, Rahul's attack on Modi's connection with industrialist Gautam Adani, whose company was accused of stock market manipulation by short-selling company Hindenburg Research, has rattled the BJP brass. "Modi often distinguishes himself from other politicians